

Photographs by SUBIR HALDER

ER SIEGE

ARJEE AND A SIGN THAT HIS HOLD ON POWER IS SLIPPING AND THE PARTY IS IN SERIOUS CRISIS

the chief minister and the Left Front Government, the first time that the intellectuals, always faithful supporters, have gone against them. Says eminent theatre person Rudraprasad Sengupta, "There is all-round frustration about the way the CPI(M) is functioning and, by default, the government. What has happened is a show of anger at the lack of democratic and planned procedures. Buddhadeb and his party have not followed the golden rule of making haste slowly. Some people in his own party have misguided him. It is sad to see that he fell for it." Sengupta's words find echo in the enormous show of strength by anti-Government protests in Kolkata on November 14 where almost all leading intellectuals and artists took part. For many, the rally was an eyeopener; sadly, nobody, least of all the chief minister and his administration, could foresee what

would happen a week later. Wednesday brought in chaos and fear which was to be seen to be believed. For the first time since 1992, Kolkata saw army flag marches and curfew.

For an outfit like the All-India Minority Forum (AIMF) and the almost non-existent Furfurasharif Muzaddia Anath Foundation, Wednesday's unprecedented violence, which singled Kolkata and led to curfew in parts of the city, was a huge victory. Not for what it achieved but for what it had done to the morale of the City of Joy. Throughout the day, an unprepared police force looked on helplessly as mobs burnt cars, pelted stones, children remained hungry and stranded in schools and innocent pedestrians who had forgotten what it was like to walk with hands up in a gesture of surrender, suffered a mindless frenzy of violence.

That there was an intelligence fail-

ure on the part of the state Government was obvious—the police were totally unprepared and did not even resort to water cannons to control the mobs. They were also handicapped by orders from the top not to resort to firing under any circumstances. By evening, with curfew imposed and rioting under control, the chief minister defended his actions, saying, "The police acted just the way a disciplined force should have." Why, however, he had to call in the army was left unsaid.

It is the unsaid part that is hurting him the most. With every passing day, Buddhadeb's silence is becoming deafening while some of his remarks on key issues are only fanning the flames and damaging his credibility. After the recent battle for Nandigram, the chief minister's first reaction was shocking: "If they attack us, we have to retaliate." The reference to the "they" and the